

Crude prices will exceed \$100

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【メール原文】

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Crude prices will exceed \$100 as the Middle East conflict drags on

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The continued standoff between the US and Iran, together with the ongoing Russia-Ukraine and Saudi-Houthi wars, will push Brent crude prices into a higher \$85-\$105 per barrel range.

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China's oil demand may be recovering, adding further pressure on crude prices.

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Over the longer term, however, the electrification of global transportation will reduce oil demand.

Strong products demand and a continued standoff in MENA will push oil prices above \$100.

Front-month Brent has risen above \$95 per barrel, exceeding Eurasia Group's price range (see: Standoff now likely to run through 2026 as Hormuz traffic increases , 1 September 2026). The main forces driving prices higher remain geopolitical conflict in the Middle East—both the US-Iran conflict in the Persian Gulf and the confrontation between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis in Yemen—as well as the Russia-Ukraine war. A shortage of global refining capacity has added further upward pressure, alongside sustained demand for refined products.

Under current conditions, oil will likely remain within an \$85-\$105 per barrel range, as Eurasia Group sees little chance of a resolution to any of the relevant conflicts.

US will keep oil moving through the Strait of Hormuz, despite Iranian attacks. Naval sources said that 15–20 vessels transited the strait between Friday and Monday, including tankers, bulk-carriers, and container ships. The US Navy continues to operate a limited assistance program for individual ships, supporting six to 12 daily transits in recent days. Several countries in Asia and Europe also provide some assistance, though public details have not been released, and the number of such assisted transits appears lower than that of the US. A smaller volume of ships continues to use the Iranian route.

The latest data from Kpler suggest that 7-8 million barrels per day (bpd) are moving through the strait, while regional exports have recovered to 12-13 million bpd, or roughly 60% of prewar flows.

Traffic flows are uneven rather than steady. The number of daily transits fluctuates from one day to the next, depending on US and Iranian military activity in the region. For example, transits through Iranian waters stopped on Sunday and Monday after US strikes on Iranian tankers. Likewise, transits through Omani waters stalled late last week after Iranian attacks on vessels there.

Despite US claims, mines likely remain present in the main waterway. The Joint Maritime Information Center (JMIC) warns that mines still pose a risk within and near the traditional commercial shipping lanes in the middle of the strait, known as the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS). The Iranian Revolutionary Guards also continue to threaten any commercial vessel attempting to use the TSS.

The critical demand-side issue will remain Chinese seaborne crude imports. Since late February, China's imports have fallen by 3.5 million bpd, as Beijing has chosen to draw on crude inventories rather than expose domestic refiners to higher prices.

The latest data suggest that import demand may be recovering, however, as Chinese buyers submit higher bids for crude deliveries and domestic refiners export larger volumes of refined products. The recovery would further support a higher price outlook, as rising Chinese demand would add pressure to crude supplies without any resolution to the Middle East or Russia-Ukraine conflicts.

Electrification will likely reduce global oil demand in 2026. Although the near-term forecast points to high prices and tight supply, longer-term trends are more bearish. Global sales of new electric vehicles (EVs), including plug-in hybrids, are expected to exceed 23 million in 2026, up from 3 million in 2020. Those sales have likely displaced 3.6 million bpd of crude demand since 2020. Once second-hand EV sales are included, total oil demand displacement could reach 5 million bpd in 2026. (Note: Oil demand displacement differs from oil demand reduction: It refers to the volume of oil consumption replaced by the shift from internal combustion engines to EVs.)

This oil displacement figure will almost certainly rise as EV sales continue to grow, especially in Asia, Europe, and South America where many governments subsidize EV sales to support domestic carmakers or to reduce reliance on fuel imports. The recent growth in electric truck and bus sales will reinforce that trend.

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